Country Profile: Armenia

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 3
- Plurality religion: Armenian Apostolic
- Official language: Armenian
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Armenians

Historical Background

Armenia declared its independence from the Soviet Union on September 21, 1991. Armenia was the only one of the 15 Soviet republics to exit the USSR under Soviet legislation. Armenia did not "restore" its statehood but declared itself an independent republic based on Articles 72, 73, and 81 of the USSR Constitution and the USSR Law of April 3, 1990.[1] The transition was marked by economic difficulties and the devastating impact of the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict with Azerbaijan, which erupted into full-scale war shortly before independence and continued into the early 1990s. Despite a ceasefire in 1994, tensions over the region have persisted throughout the focus period of the Nation-Building Policies (NBP) dataset.

Groups

The group composition of Armenia in the NBP dataset includes the three groups mentioned in the EPR and AMAR datasets as well as in the Minority Rights directory. Armenia is a highly monoethnic country, with almost all inhabitants belonging to the core group of ethnic Armenians. Armenia also has one of the smallest shares of Russians in the whole post-Soviet space.

- **Armenians** constitute the overwhelming majority of the population in Armenia, making up about 98% of the country's population.[2] Armenians speak the Eastern Armenian language and adhere to the Armenian Apostolic religion.[3] The

[1] Epstein, 2016.
[2] ARMSTAT, 2022.
[3] Ethnologue, 2024; EPR-ED, 2021.

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municipality of Gyumri became a significant refuge for large numbers of Armenian refugees escaping the Ottoman Empire during the Armenian Genocide, leading to the presence of Western Armenian speakers.[4] Armenians are also fluent in Russian.

- **Kurds/Yezidis** are a nested religious group of Sunni Islam adherents, consisting of Kurdish and Yezidi communities. The Kurdish presence in Armenia began with the Shaddadid dynasty in the 10th century, with a significant increase in the Kurdish population occurring in the 18th century due to tribal migrations to the Ararat plain.[5] Yezidis began to arrive in Armenia in the early half of the 19th century as they fled Ottoman oppression.[6] The 2022 Census registered 31,077 Yezidis and 1,663 Kurds in Armenia, accounting for 1.2% of the total population.[7] Yezidis were not classified separately from Kurds in the Soviet censuses, as the Soviet espousal of atheism meant that minority religious identities were disregarded. Yezidis claim that the Kurmanji dialect they speak is a separate language from Kurdish. However, Yezidi religious texts are written in Kurdish, and many members of the Yezidi communities in other countries consider themselves to be Kurdish.[8] This debate has split the Yezidi community in Armenia over the decades. Kurds in Armenia speak Northern Kurdish.[9]
- **Assyrians** living in Armenia speak the Assyrian Neo-Aramaic language and adhere to Syriac Orthodoxy.[10] The modern Assyrian community in Armenia largely formed during the 19th and early 20th centuries, with significant migration occurring around World War I and the collapse of the Ottoman Empire.[11] Assyrians primarily live in a few villages and towns, with notable communities in villages such as Verin Dvin, Nor Artagers, and Arzni.[12] They also reside in urban centers like Yerevan and compose around 0.1% of the total population.[13]

[4] Minority Rights, 2024; Ethnologue, 2024.
[5] Minority Rights, 2024.
[6] Ibid.
[7] Minority Rights, 2024.
[8] Minority Rights, 2024.
[9] Ethnologue, 2024.
[10] EPR-ED, 2021.
[11] Minority Rights, 2024.
[12] Ibid.
[13] ARMSTAT, 2022.

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State Profile

Official Language

The official language of Armenia is Armenian in accordance with Article 20 of the 1995 Constitution. Armenian is a distinct language with its own script dating to the early 5th century. The language is central to Armenian cultural and national identity and it is used in government, education, media, and daily communication.

Official Religion

The overwhelming majority of the population of Armenia are Christians of the Armenian Apostolic Church, which possesses the status of the national church of the Armenian people.[14] Armenia is renowned for being the first nation to adopt Christianity as its state religion in 301 CE, under the reign of King Tiridates III and through the evangelistic efforts of St. Gregory the Illuminator. Nonetheless, the 1995 Constitution explicitly declares the separation of the church and state in Article 17.[15]

Education Policies

In Armenia, pre-school education is available for children aged 3 to 6 years. Kindergartens are provided by both the state and private institutions. Compulsory education in Armenia starts at age 6 and lasts until the completion of secondary education at age 17 or 18. Public schools and universities are primarily funded by the government, while private institutions rely on tuition fees and private funding. There is **no evidence of segregation** in Armenian schools based on sex, race, class, or ethnicity.[16]

Private schools have not faced restrictions in Armenia according to the 1999 Law on Education. Non-state organizations own, run, and provide funding for non-state schools, primarily through student fees. According to the 1999 Law on Education (as amended in 2015), non-state schools are required to comply with state education standards but can, with prior state authorization, include alternative syllabuses in their school charter.[17]

[14] Constitution of the Republic of Armenia, 1995.
[15] Ibid.
[16] Scolaro Database, 2024.
[17] UNESCO, 2021.

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Language Education Policies

The official language of instruction in Armenia is Armenian. All public and most private schools use Armenian as the primary language for teaching and learning. According to the 1993 Law of the Republic of Armenia on Language, in communities of national minorities, general education may be organized in their native language; however, it must follow the state program and obtain the state patronage and include compulsory teaching of the Armenian language. In 1993, Assyrian and Northern Kurdish were incorporated as languages of instruction in regions with a large Assyrian or Kurdish population. Assyrian was also used as an optional language class in primary and secondary schools. Minority education in Russian was provided through mandatory language classes for the entire country, but minority schools in Russian were limited. However, the continued expansion of state schools offering instruction in Russian signaled the existence of Russian as a language of instruction.[18,19] Due to historical ties with Russia and the prevalence of Russian speakers, Russian has been the most commonly taught foreign language in Armenian schools. It is introduced as a second language starting from the early grades and is a mandatory subject throughout primary and secondary education.[20]

Religious Education Policies

Armenian schools have taught students the history of the country's Apostolic Church since 2002. In 2005, the history of religion became compulsory for children over nine. Two years later, the church gained the right to design the educational program and to nominate teachers. That same year, the Center for Christian Instruction in Etchmiadzin, the seat of the Apostolic Church, took over control of the syllabus.[21]

Bans and Restrictions

According to Section 8 of the Law of the Republic of Armenia on the Freedom of Conscience and on Religious Organizations, proselytism within the Republic of Armenia is forbidden.[22]

[18] National Assembly of the Republic of Armenia, 1993.
[19] Dum-Tragut and Gyozalyan, 2007.
[20] Sahakyan, 2021.
[21] Mkrtchyan, 2013.
[22] National Assembly of the Republic of Armenia, 1991.

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Constitutions and Laws

The Constitutional Law of the Republic of Armenia of September 25, 1991, "On the Fundamentals of Independent Statehood" declared that any legislation that does not comply with the 1990 Independence Declaration is considered no longer in force.[23] However, it left the room for the 1978 Constitution of the Armenian SSR to remain partially in force. The 1978 Constitution does not refer to specific ethnic groups or religions, but it had provisions on the state language and religious freedom.[24]

The 1995 Constitution of Armenia does not make explicit reference to Armenians within the country; however, special emphasis is put on developing comprehensive ties and preserving Armenianness with the Armenian diaspora abroad. The document stresses protection of the Armenian language and Armenian historical and cultural values in other countries.[25] This constitution guarantees the freedom of activity of religious organizations and their separation from the state (Article 17). At the same time, Article 18 recognizes the exceptional mission of the Armenian Apostolic Holy Church, as the national church, in developing national culture and preserving the national identity.[26] These provisions are also enshrined in the following constitutional revisions.

The 1995 Constitution of Armenia underwent major amendments in 2005 and 2015 following national referendums. However, these changes did not alter the general provisions related to language, religion, or the rights of national minorities.

Citizenship Laws

The current citizenship regime in Armenia, established by the 1995 Law on Citizenship, does not exclude any specific groups from accessing citizenship. There is no provision for birthright citizenship for children born to foreign parents unless one parent is a citizen of Armenia or the parents are stateless or of unknown citizenship.[27] Additionally, there are no country-based differences in the naturalization process; however, ethnic Armenians, regardless of their country of residence, can apply for citizenship through a simplified procedure that often waives the residency requirement.[28]

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[23] Zakon.ru, 2021.
[24] Constitution of the Armenian Soviet Socialist Republic, 1978.
[25] Constitution of the Republic of Armenia, 1995 (rev. 2015).
[26] Constitution of the Republic of Armenia, 1995 (rev. 2015).
[27] Makaryan, 2013.
[28] Parliament of the Republic of Armenia, 1995.

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National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Armenia is titled "Mer Hayrenik," which translates to "Our Fatherland." It was adopted in 1991 and is based on the anthem of the First Armenian Republic (1918–1920). The lyrics, only available in Armenian, were written by Mikael Nalbandian, and the music was composed by Barsegh Kanachyan. "Mer Hayrenik" is a patriotic song that celebrates the beauty, strength, and resilience of the Armenian nation. It reflects the pride of the Armenian people in their historical heritage and their enduring spirit. The anthem calls upon Armenians to cherish and protect their country, emphasizing themes of freedom, unity, and national pride. It is an expression of hope and determination, highlighting the sacrifices made for the nation's independence and the ongoing commitment to its prosperity.[29]

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[29] President of the Republic of Armenia, 1991.

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